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Instrument 15 — The Product Differentiation Scorecard *(Chapter 15)*

Run this for two or three comparable products: never one; a single-vendor evaluation can only answer "is this impressive?"

1. **Weighted criteria, before any demo.** Anchor them to your patients and your operation, and rank and weight them before vendor narratives arrive. Mark each as a must-pass gate or a differentiator. Criteria written after the demos are rationalizations with a rubric.

2. **Comparison set.** Two or three products minimum, never one. Only comparison answers "is this better, for us, at this price, with this burden?"

3. **Team composition.** Not just executives and reviewers but the people who do the work the technology will touch, including the translator-operator and frontline reviewers, who become the change's champions afterward.

4. **Reference-call question set** (real references, beyond the curated list): What did this actually feel like inside your health system? What worked with that team that was genuinely great? What didn't work? What were the challenges, and how did you overcome them, and how did they help? Were there problems they couldn't address, and who finally did? How did it turn out, and how did the whole experience feel in the end: any negative feelings, and about what?

5. **The master question:** *What has to happen inside our system for the value in this demo to become real, and who carries each step?* Walk it with named carriers and honest hours across vendor, IT, operations, physicians, nurses and MAs, compliance and legal, training, finance, and patient.

6. **Three follow-ups:** Where might the saved work reappear? What would make us regret this purchase in a year? If the founding team disappeared from this deployment tomorrow, would it still work?

7. **The final buyer question:** *Which product can our institution live with, support, govern, and renew?*, not which performs best in the demo.

8. **The investor reversal.** Simulate the customer's bake-off: ask which structured comparisons the company has won, which it has lost, and — most revealing — why it lost, in the company's own telling.

9. **The why-it-lost log.** For each bake-off lost, record the buyer segment, the winning alternative, the criterion that decided the loss, the operational reason behind it, and whether the loss reflects product weakness, buyer mismatch, pricing/burden, governance maturity, integration/supportability, or customer readiness.

Score independently against the weighted criteria, then deliberate as a group; the disagreements are the findings.